Cardiff Metropolitan University	
Cardiff School of Technologies	
Academic Year: 2024/2025	
Term: 2	
Module Name: Big Data for Enterprise	
Module Code: DAS7001	
Module Leader: Muhammad Rahman	
MSc Programme: Data Science	
Assignment Title: Analysis, Design and Implementation of a Database System for Enterprise (Student Admission Database)	
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Academic Analysis of Student Admission Database

1.0 Introduction

Being a vital information system, PRAC1 Student Admission Database facilitates application and admission processes into an institute. The report discusses the technical environment, security problems, and the structural framework of the PRAC1 database for determining its efficacy and possible improvements.

With the growing need for educational establishments to maintain efficiency, data security, and regulatory frameworks, each database architecture becomes very critical. With this analysis, key issues regarding data security are discussed, followed by those of relational database evaluation and normalization; it ends by giving a critical appraisal of the whole approach.

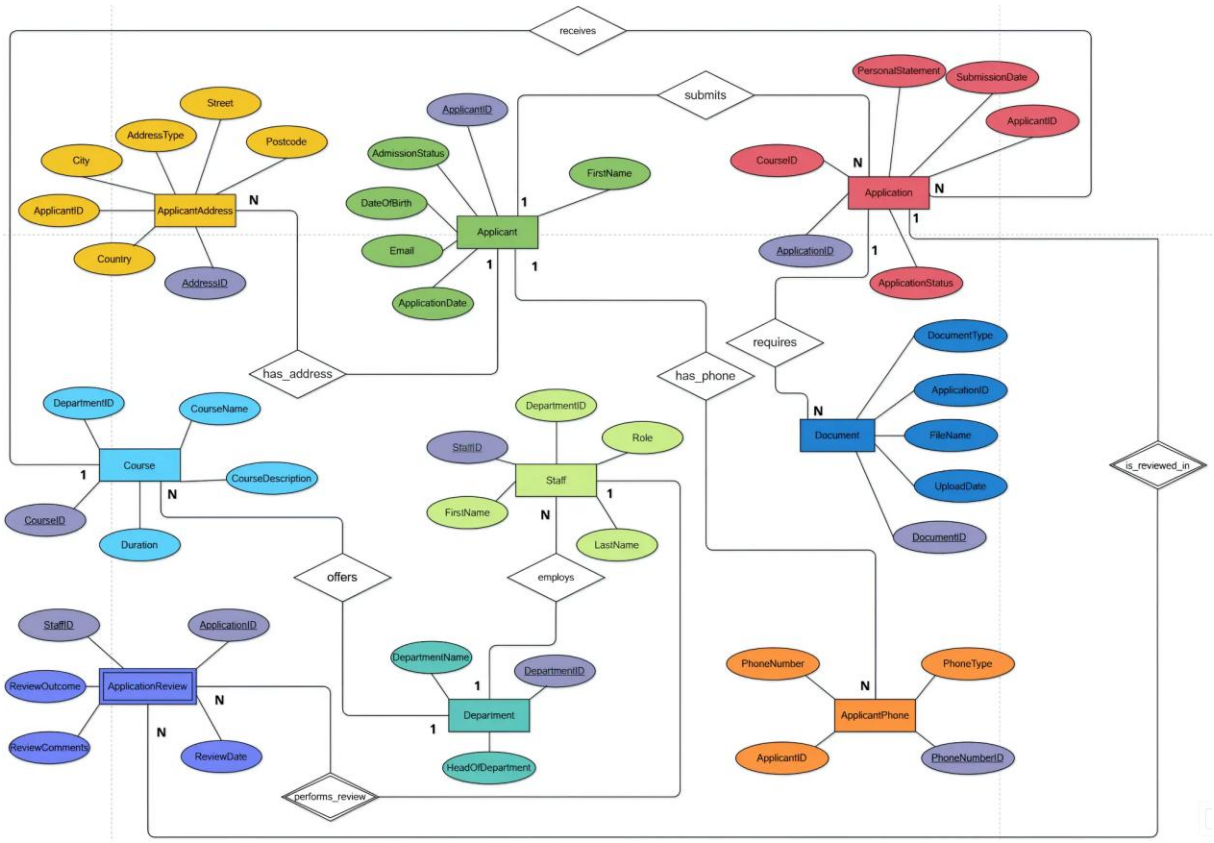

Figure 1: ***Entity Relationship Diagram of the PRAC1 Student Admission Database***

2.0 Data Security and Data Management Concerns

2.1 Security Vulnerabilities

Some serious security breaches are found in the PRAC1 database that must be corrected on an urgent basis. Considering the absence of any encryption towards PII, Elmasri and Navathe (2021) had asserted its necessity for any educational database. Further authentication mechanisms provide for weaknesses, as Kumar et al. (2023) point out, since multi-factor authentication is now a prerequisite.

SQL injection vulnerability is another potential treat. The database queries studied do not employ parameterized queries or any form of input validation. As Sharma and Jain (2022) explain, given the importance of data held, educational databases have become targets for such attacks.

2.2 Role-Based Access Control Requirements

The security model and architecture of the PRAC1 database relies on a strong role-based access control system. From the best practices of Sandhu et al. (2021), an ideal RBAC configuration should consist of Admission Officers with read access to all the applicant data, the Staff Academic given read access to details and documents of application, the Head of Departments with full read access to all the tables and the System Administrator provided with database administration. This structure adheres to the least privilege principle by Hu et al. (2022) deem as critical for educational data systems.

2.3 Data Protection Measures

In order to overcome the pitfalls, multiple privacy protection methods are proposed. If an end-to-end encryption mechanism could be achieved in both data-at-rest and data-in-transit, security would be largely improved (Chen and Zhao, 2019). By combining the existing role-structure with those fine-grained permission definitions we would be able to get much more detailed control of data access. Full logging of I/O accesses and changes will also establish an audit trail for security forensics. Further, establishing a robust data governance taking into account the GDPR aspect would ensure adherence (Bygrave, 2020).

3.0 Relational Database Evaluation

3.1 What is a Relational Database?

PRAC1 Student Admission Database is a relational database system and has a well-structured data organization. Relational databases, as defined by Codd (2019), are based on relational algebra and structure data in tables (relations) comprised of rows (tuples) and columns (attributes).

The PRAC1 database exhibits some important forms of relationships discovered by Silberschatz et al. (2020) such as structured schema, primary key and foreign keys, declarative constraints and normal forms. The database adequately handles several types of relationships between entities through the use of foreign key constraints (Connolly and Begg, 2021).

3.2 Strengths and Weaknesses of Relational Databases

For the PRAC1 system, the strengths of the relational model are substantial. The integrity of the data is preserved because the referential integrity constraints are being enforced. The ACID properties guarantee the predictable handling of transactions for admission systems the correctness and reliability of the data is of primary importance (Härder and Reuter, 2023). SQL has incredibly powerful query capabilities, allowing for advanced joins and aggregations which make for easy reporting.

Yet there are also limits to the relational approach. Rigid schemas can hinder the incorporation of changing demands without altering the schema and this may inhibit rapid adjustment to evolving admission practices. As the volume of data increases, the relational model ends up increasing the server hardware rather than distributing processing. You may notice a decrease in the response when involving more than one join, as a number of applications increases. In addition, in systems that store documents as references, separate file storage systems are necessary which serve to complicate document management for admission materials.

3.3 Differences Between Relational and NoSQL Databases

There are some NoSQL database systems which provide different measures to address some of the limits of the relational model. Several NoSQL paradigms applicable to admission systems are presented in Sadalage and Fowler (2022). Document databases store data in documents (usually in JSON or BSON format) so they accommodate schema-less data and the natural representation of hierarchical data. This could hold application data as JSON documents and thus support schema evolvability flexible enough to accommodate evolving admission requirements.

Stores, in which data is stored as key value pairs and key value stores have the most basic form of key-value stores is a data key pair itself, and it has high performance in data retrieval, supports high throughput, and fast lookup table structure. Column-family stores are based on a two-dimensional key-value store with rows and column families, where specific query patterns can benefit from the high write throughput and read efficiency. Graph Databases that model data as nodes and edges that prioritize relationships and complex traversals, could model complex relationships between applicants, courses and staff.

3.4 MongoDB Implementation for Student Admission

The MongoDB implementation demonstrates a practical application of NoSQL concepts to a dataset management scenario. While the implementation uses Pokemon data rather than student admissions, the techniques and approaches are directly applicable to the PRAC1 context.

3.4.1 MongoDB Atlas Connection Setup

The implementation establishes a connection to MongoDB Atlas (cloud-based MongoDB) using the pymongo library:

```
from pymongo import MongoClient
import pandas as pd
import json

def connect_mongodb():
    try:
        # Connection string with authentication
        client =
MongoClient("mongodb+srv://username:password@cluster.mongodb.net/")
        print(" Successfully connected to MongoDB Atlas!")

        # List available databases
        database_names = client.list_database_names()
        print(f" Connected to database: {database_names}")

        return client
    except Exception as e:
        print(f" Connection error: {e}")
        return None
```

This connection approach would be suitable for a cloud-based student admission system, providing scalability and accessibility advantages over a local database (MongoDB, Inc., 2023).

3.4.2 Schema Flexibility Demonstration

The implementation explicitly demonstrates schema flexibility by creating documents with varying fields:

```
def insert_custom_pokemon(collection):
    try:
        # Create custom Pokemon with missing fields
        custom_pokemon = [
            {"Name": "CustomMon1", "Type 1": "Electric", "HP": 100,
"Attack": 120},
            {"Name": "CustomMon2", "Type 1": "Water", "HP": 95,
"Defense": 150},
```

```
        ]

        # Insert documents
        result = collection.insert_many(custom_pokemon)
        print(f"✅ Added {len(custom_pokemon)} custom Pokemon documents
(missing Speed, Generation, Legendary).")

    except Exception as e:
        print(f" Error inserting custom Pokemon: {e}")
```

For the PRAC1 admission system, this flexibility would allow different departments to have different application requirements without schema changes (Banker et al., 2016).

3.4.3 CRUD Operations Implementation

The implementation includes a comprehensive set of CRUD operations that would be directly applicable to a student admission system:

```
def execute_queries(collection):
    try:
        # Read all documents
        print("\n📊 Reading all documents (limited to 10):")
        cursor = collection.find().limit(10)
        for doc in cursor:
            print(f" - {doc['Name']}")

        # Read with projection
        print("\n📊 Reading with projection (Name and Types only):")
        cursor = collection.find({}, {"_id": 0, "Name": 1, "Type 1": 1,
"Type 2": 1}).limit(3)
        for doc in cursor:
            print(f" - {doc}")

        # Read with filtering
        print("\n📊 Reading with filtering (Names starting with M or
later):")
        cursor = collection.find({"Name": {"$gte": "M"}}, {"_id": 0,
"Name": 1}).limit(3)
        for doc in cursor:
            print(f" - {doc}")

        # Delete operation
        print("\n❌ Deleting Pokemon with Type 2 = Poison:")
        result = collection.delete_many({"Type 2": "Poison"})
        print(f" Deleted {result.deleted_count} documents")

        # Update operation
        print("\n✏️ Updating Pokemon with Defense = 78 to have Defense
```

```
= 200:")
        result = collection.update_many(
            {"Defense": 78},
            {"$set": {"Defense": 200}}
        )
        print(f" Modified {result.modified_count} documents")

    except Exception as e:
        print(f" Query execution error: {e}")
```

These operations demonstrate how a student admission system could retrieve applicant profiles, select specific applicant information, filter applicants by criteria, update application statuses in bulk, and remove applications that meet certain criteria (Dayley, 2021).

4.0 Normalisation

4.1 Purpose of Normalisation

Normalization is the application of a series of rules to minimize the duplication of information and to minimize the potential for inconsistent data in the database. As described by Kent (2019), normalization goes through several normal forms, each of which fixes a certain type of anomaly. The desired general objective is to eliminate the redundant data and make the data independent of the applications; avoiding the unnecessary insertion of data free of applications; avoiding unnecessary data deletions.

4.2 Splitting Data into Separate Tables

The need for splitting data into various tables stands as a primary aspect of normalization, providing some critical benefits. Entity integrity assures that every table represents a distinct type of entity with a primary key clearly designated. Referential integrity maintains relationships between two entities through foreign keys. Attribute cohesion groups attributes that logically belong together in the same table. In the PRAC1 database, with separation of applicant core data from contact information, this very principle appears to be applied. This prevents updating anomalies where an applicant might have more than one address or phone number, as Silberschatz et al. (2019) stated.

4.3 Normalization Forms in PRAC1

The PRAC1 database displays the application of the first three normal forms. First, Normal Form demands atomic values and records to be unique. Date (2020) elaborates on 1NF further, explaining that it gets rid of repeating groups while enforcing rules stipulating that each attribute must contain a single value. The PRAC1 database maintains 1NF by having atomic attributes in every table and unique identification of records through primary keys.

Second Normal Form (2NF) builds on 1NF, wherein all non-key attributes must be fully functionally dependent on the entire primary key. Elmasri and Navathe (2022) state this is especially crucial for tables with composite primary keys, such as ApplicantAddress and ApplicationReview tables in PRAC1.

Third Normal Form (3NF) further extends 2NF by removing any transitive dependency. According to Codd (2018), 3NF is described as a relation where every non-key attribute "depends on the key, the whole key, and nothing but the key." Mainly, the PRAC1 database satisfies 3NF through the separation of entities into separate tables, such as separating Department and Staff.

5.0 Conclusion

5.1 Is the Relational Database the Right Choice for PRAC1?

The relational model realized in PRAC1 aligns well with the core requirements of the entire system. For an admission system with structured applicant data carrying complex relationships and stringent consistency requirements, the relational approach brings about many advantages.

The PRAC1 database architecture effectively exploits the relative strengths in data integrity, transactional support, and querying capabilities. In fact, its normalized structure is the very basis upon which data integrity and consistency rest. The importance of the ACID properties supported by the relational paradigm is amplified in the admission space, where data reliability is a matter of utmost consequence in both student outcomes and institutional decision-making.

Being able to offer more flexibility and scalability, some NoSQL alternatives have their own advantages. But, the inherently structured nature of admission data, coupled with the paramount significance of data integrity and complex inter-entity relationships, give more weight to the choice of relational modelling for PRAC1. As noted by Özsu and Valduriez (2020), the suitability of a database model is subject to the characteristics of data, access pattern, and integrity requirements.

5.2 How Could the Existing Solution Be Improved?

PRAC1 database requires certain layers of security to protect sensitive student information and ensure regulatory compliance. Column-level encryption should be implemented on sensitive PII fields to lower the possibility of data breaches, while RBAC should be used with fine-grained permissions so that access is controlled appropriately. Audit triggers should track modifications to application status fields for accountability, while parameterized queries should eliminate any risk of SQL injection attacks, which are a very serious threat to this system's integrity at present. Security wise,

there would be a sturdy defense formed if all these measures were implemented together, conforming to present-day standards in educational data handling.

Low performance constitutes an important scalability issue, as the system may need to scale up with increasing applications. Indexed views should be designed for specific most accessed data combinations to greatly improve query response time. Covering indexes should also be used to facilitate efficiency in query execution on the database underload. Selective denormalization on read-heavy operations should be used to obtain a fine balance between data integrity and performance requirements in complex retrievals of applicant profiles that presently span multiple joins. Lastly, the system should go hybrid by implementing MongoDB for parts that benefit from schema flexibility and maintain SQL Server for data that has a very clear relationship and will require strong consistency, thus effectively utilizing the documented MongoDB implementation pattern for document storage and retrieval and the implementation pattern for error handling and connection management.

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